WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

CURAÇAO

Americas

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Willemstad (Punda, Otrobanda and Pietermaai)	Capital, main port city and commercial and financial centre of this autonomous country within the Kingdom of the Netherlands, home to most government, banking and professional-services activity	Financial and professional services, hospitality, real estate, retail
Coastal resort areas and Pietermaai	Engine of a tourism economy that drew a record 788,427 stay-over visitors in 2025, with new branded hotels and apartment complexes adding capacity	Hotels and resorts, residential tourism, leisure and food and beverage
Bullenbaai oil terminal (west coast)	Deep-water crude terminal back in commercial use in 2026, loading its first very large crude carrier in nearly a decade in May 2026	Oil storage, transshipment, marine and terminal services
Emmastad / Isla refinery complex	Historic 335,000 b/d refinery idle since 2019, with government policy now focused on a service model built around terminals, storage and logistics	Energy logistics, site redevelopment, industrial services
Harbour Free Economic Zone (Willemstad)	Curinde-managed customs-free zone beside the port for storage, assembly and re-export to regional markets	Logistics, warehousing, distribution, light assembly
Airport Free Economic Zone and Curaçao International Airport	Air gateway linking the island to the Netherlands, North America and South America, with an adjacent Curinde-managed free zone	Air cargo, e-commerce fulfilment, aviation services
Brievengat Industrial Park	Curinde business park offering serviced industrial sites for local and export-oriented production	Light manufacturing, workshops, services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Curaçao Investment and Export Promotion Agency (CINEX) acts as the first point of contact for investors and runs targeted outreach such as the Curaçao Investment Roundtable in Miami in April 2026
- Economic zones (e-zones) taxing qualifying profits at 2% for companies with real presence that trade or serve clients abroad, with local sales capped at 25% of turnover and subject to approval
- Curinde, 85% government-owned, manages the Harbour and Airport Free Economic Zones and Brievengat Industrial Park, offering duty-free storage, assembly and re-export

- Caribbean guilder (Cg), introduced on 31 March 2025 and fixed at Cg 1.79 = $1.00, managed by the Centrale Bank van Curaçao en Sint Maarten (CBCS), which also licenses and supervises financial institutions
- Energy-logistics entry through 2BAYS and its subsidiary Curaçao Refinery Utilities (CRU), which operate the Bullenbaai terminal; any Venezuela-linked activity must comply with US OFAC General License 46 conditions
- Online gaming licences issued solely by the Curaçao Gaming Authority under the National Ordinance on Games of Chance (LOK), in force since 24 December 2024, replacing the former master-licence system
- Listing and capital-raising through the Dutch Caribbean Securities Exchange (DCSX), which signed a co-promotion agreement with CINEX in March 2025

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Curaçao enters late 2026 with solid momentum. Preliminary official figures show real GDP growth of 5.1% in 2025, led by accommodation and food services (+10.8%), financial services (+9.8%) and construction (+9.4%), and the government's mid-2026 projections, based on CBCS forecasts, point to further growth of 2.7% in 2026 with inflation of about 2.4%. Stay-over arrivals reached a record 788,427 in 2025 (+13%) and rose a further 9% in the first half of 2026, while cruise passengers totalled 881,665 in 2025. Public finances have improved markedly: consecutive budget surpluses have reduced central government debt from 90.3% of GDP in 2021 to 64.7% in 2024, with the IMF projecting around 60% for 2025, and tax receipts in the first half of 2026 were about Cg 98 million above the previous year. The external position has strengthened too, with the monetary union's current account deficit narrowing from 17% to 8% of GDP in 2025 and reserves covering 5.5 months of imports in May 2026.

Curaçao's main structural challenge is diversifying beyond tourism after the closure of the Isla refinery in 2019, which for a century anchored the island's industry. The government is turning this into an opportunity by shifting toward a service-oriented energy model based on terminals, storage and logistics: the Bullenbaai terminal has received multiple crude tankers since the start of 2026 and loaded close to 2 million barrels for China, India and Europe in May 2026. US OFAC General License 46, issued in January 2026, creates a lawful but tightly conditioned channel for Venezuelan-origin crude logistics. Beyond energy, the IMF points to yachting, maritime services, data centres, renewable energy and new South American markets as diversification routes, supported by the dollar peg, a fiscal rule, rising reserves and Curaçao's place within the Kingdom of the Netherlands, each creating openings for early movers.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Concentration on tourism and two source markets	Tourism drives growth, and the Netherlands (31%) and the United States (27%) supplied most stay-over visitors in the first half of 2026	Fast growth from Canada, Colombia, Brazil and Argentina is broadening the base and creating openings in airlift, hospitality and services
Refinery closure and Venezuela sanctions compliance	The Isla refinery has been idle since 2019; Venezuela-linked oil activity is permitted only within the conditions of US OFAC General License 46, which excludes upstream work and requires US-law contracts	Engage sanctions counsel and the 2BAYS/CRU structure; lawful terminal, storage and logistics services offer a near-term opportunity
AML/CFT framework	The July 2025 CFATF mutual evaluation placed Curaçao in enhanced follow-up, and the IMF has called for significant improvement	The government reports progress on supervision and beneficial-ownership transparency; robust compliance and reputable local banks and advisers support investors
Labour market and skills	Unemployment was 7.8% in 2024 and the population is ageing, and the IMF notes informality and skills mismatches	The IMF recommends streamlined permits for high-skilled workers; investment in training and workforce solutions is welcomed
Electricity costs and grid capacity	The IMF notes that power costs and grid capacity need to be addressed before data centres and large-scale renewables	Early investors in renewable generation, storage and efficiency can help shape and

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	can expand	benefit from this transition
Small, import-dependent economy	Most goods are imported, chiefly from the United States and the Netherlands, so the trade balance depends on services earnings	The fixed dollar peg removes currency risk; the free zones support regional distribution and import-substitution niches
Pace of public investment	The IMF notes public investment is being ramped up slowly under the fiscal rule and Kingdom financial supervision	Fiscal space from consecutive surpluses supports a pipeline of infrastructure projects; engage early on port, transport and maritime tenders

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Curaçao's risk profile is that of a stable island economy with a currency fixed to the US dollar, improving public finances and the institutional anchor of the Kingdom of the Netherlands. Debt has fallen by roughly a third relative to GDP since 2021, budgets are guided by a fiscal rule, reserves have reached their strongest level in years and the banking sector is broadly sound. The main considerations for investors are reliance on tourism, the transition from refining to an energy-services model and continued work on the AML/CFT framework following the 2025 CFATF evaluation. Investors in oil logistics should note plainly that dealings involving Venezuelan-origin crude are lawful only within the strict conditions of US OFAC General License 46, and should take specialist sanctions advice before committing. With record visitor numbers, a revived Bullenbaai terminal and a clear diversification agenda, the outlook remains constructive.

MARKET ACCESS

Curaçao is an autonomous constituent country of the Kingdom of the Netherlands; it is not part of the EU but is associated with it as an Overseas Country and Territory (OCT), giving its goods preferential access to the EU market, and its nationals hold Dutch and therefore EU citizenship. It participates in the WTO through the Kingdom of the Netherlands and shares a monetary union and central bank with Sint Maarten. The United States and the Netherlands are the main suppliers of imports, while goods exports go mainly to Bonaire, the Netherlands, Aruba and the United States. Curaçao's principal export is services, led by tourism, financial services and port activity. Its deep-water harbour, free zones and proximity to the Venezuelan coast make it a natural hub between North America, South America and Europe for logistics and energy storage.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Gilmar Pisas)	Leads government policy and directly oversees Kingdom affairs and the state energy companies 2BAYS, Aqualectra and Curoil	Primary reference point for strategic priorities, including energy-sector decisions
Curaçao Investment and Export Promotion Agency (CINEX)	National investment promotion agency running investor outreach in tourism, logistics, finance, energy, technology and real estate	Standard first point of contact for market entry and introductions
Centrale Bank van Curaçao en Sint Maarten (CBCS)	Maintains the Caribbean guilder peg, sets the 4.25% pledging rate and supervises banks and financial institutions	Relevant for banking, licensing and foreign exchange matters
Ministry of Economic Development	Sets economic diversification policy and approves e-zone companies' dealings with the local market	Relevant for licensing, e-zone status and sector incentives
2BAYS and Curaçao Refinery Utilities (CRU)	State companies controlling the Bullenbaai terminal and Emmastad refinery site, and the counterpart for any operator or storage arrangement	Essential partner for energy, storage and logistics investment

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Curinde	Majority state-owned manager of the Harbour and Airport Free Economic Zones and Brievengat Industrial Park	Key counterpart for logistics, distribution and light-industry entry
Curaçao Tourist Board	Markets the destination and publishes monthly visitor data by source market	Essential partner for hospitality, airlift and tourism-product investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

CINEX is the main organiser of investor engagement, hosting closed-door roundtables abroad such as the April 2026 Miami event with Banco Sabadell and partnering with the Curaçao Tourist Board on the CHICOS hotel investment conference held in Curaçao in November 2025. The Curaçao Chamber of Commerce and Industry is the business registry and liaison body, and the Dutch Caribbean Securities Exchange co-promotes the island's financial sector with CINEX. Kingdom channels, including the Dutch government and the Kingdom's financial-supervision framework, are an important route into larger public projects, while the island's OCT status links it to EU cooperation programmes. The IMF's regular Article IV reviews provide an independent reference on policy direction.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Curaçao suits investors seeking a dollar-pegged jurisdiction within the Kingdom of the Netherlands with a growing services economy: hotel, resort and residential-tourism developers serving record visitor demand from Europe and the Americas; energy-logistics, storage and marine-services companies able to work within US sanctions conditions at Bullenbaai; distribution and e-commerce businesses using the 2% e-zone regime and Curinde's free zones; and renewable-energy, storage and data-centre investors aligned with the IMF's diversification agenda. Financial-services, fintech and licensed gaming operators with strong compliance frameworks, and maritime and yachting businesses, can also find attractive openings.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage CINEX and map sector opportunities
Open dialogue with the investment promotion agency to identify priority sectors, available sites and introductions to government and private partners.

STEP 2: Assess e-zone and free-zone structuring
Evaluate the 2% e-zone regime and Curinde's Harbour and Airport Free Economic Zones for trading, distribution and services aimed at regional markets.

STEP 3: Take sanctions advice before any energy-logistics engagement
Work with sanctions counsel and 2BAYS/CRU to confirm that any Bullenbaai storage or transshipment activity fits within US OFAC General License 46.

STEP 4: Build compliance into financial, fintech and gaming entry
Plan for CBCS licensing, Curaçao Gaming Authority requirements under the LOK and strengthened AML/CFT standards from the outset.

STEP 5: Align with tourism and infrastructure growth
Use Curaçao Tourist Board market data and the government's investment agenda to target hospitality, airlift, port and renewable-energy projects.